and cutting off access to new technologies and innovations from abroad led to India achieving what has been derisively called the ‘Hindu rate of growth’. Nehru was a global leader with very sound democratic credentials. He built the institutions of democracy and higher education and landmark projects like the Bhakra Nangal dam. However, after seventeen years of his leadership, India plunged into one of its worst food crises. Low economic growth had turned the country non-competitive, largely insular and highly indebted.

Indira Gandhi enjoyed tremendous popular appeal and support, especially after the creation of Bangladesh, which broke Pakistan. She won more than 350 seats in the Lok Sabha in 1972. She remained prime minister for about fifteen years. When she spoke, the country listened, mesmerized.

Her choice of economic policies, however, proved worse than those of Jawaharlal Nehru. She killed private financial industry by nationalizing banks. She subjugated private industry by making the licence permit raj at its most stringent. She raised marginal income tax rates to 97 per cent which ensured there was no interest and enthusiasm left to establish and operate profitable enterprises. She brought in several laws to control enterprise and animal spirits in the name of monopolies control, rent control and serving the poor. She nationalized the wholesale grain trade as well though it was a short-lived misadventure. As a consequence, India became a closed economy, producing substandard goods at high costs that people were forced to consume having no choice. There were endless waits for even such shoddy products. Scooters were delivered ten years after you booked them. The same was the case with telephone connections. The cement you booked after paying an advance was allotted to you well after your house had been constructed. The slogan of ‘*Garibi Hatao*’ proved vacuous. The nation became far poorer under her rule.

The Indian Republic has completed seventy-four years by now. Half this time—thirty-seven years—had passed when Indira Gandhi was assassinated